

Report Part Title: China's Rise and Liberalism

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China's Rise and Liberalism

Since the 1970s, the People's Republic of China (PRC) has emerged as an important actor with regard to global governance. China has acquired membership of various institutions of international cooperation, most notably the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) in 1971 and the WTO in 2001. China is in many ways different from the powers that have shaped global governance so far. From the 1940s, and even more so after 1990, the United States and its Western allies heavily influenced the evolution of the system of global governance. These countries favour a strong role for liberal values in international relations, and support the expansion of norms related to economic liberalism and liberal democracy. However, the Chinese government is no supporter of liberalism, neither internationally nor domestically. The country itself is not a liberal democracy, and its economy, although partly liberalized since the 1980s, remains firmly controlled by the state.

Theorizing about the relationship between the rise of China and norms based on liberalism in international relations can take a number of forms. One possibility is to take a liberal perspective, by arguing that liberalism will prove to be the end of history. In this view, although China certainly comes from a different past, its future is liberal, in which it will accept economic and political norms based on liberalism, and institutions as universally true and applicable, by the virtue of reason. Within this liberal framework, it might be expected that China will change the international order in practice, while adopting liberalism in theoretical essence. China's rise would thus be part of the evolution of the system, rather than the end of it. However, a theory on the other side of the ideological spectrum would say that China will turn out to be a radically different kind of superpower than any that we have seen so far, with its rise bringing a fundamentally different ideological system to the table. Such a theory rejects the assumption of the universality of liberal values and puts forward a communitarian approach to the theory and practice of international political order, relying on notions of Chinese essentialism.

G. John Ikenberry is clearly a proponent of the liberal view, as he states:

“ China and other emerging great powers do not want to contest the basic rules and principles of the liberal international order; they wish to gain more authority and leadership within it. Indeed, today's power transition represents not the defeat of the post-1945 world order, in which liberalism plays a major role, but its ultimate ascendance.¹⁹

19 Ikenberry, 'The Future of the Liberal World Order', pp. 57–58.

Ikenberry argues that there are several reasons for this liberal international order to persist. First, the period since 1945 is the longest period of 'great power peace' in modern history. According to Ikenberry, this is because of the dominance of democracy, assuming that democratic countries are less likely to wage war in general and especially on one another, and because of nuclear deterrence, which raises the cost of war. It would not be in any party's interest to disrupt such a peaceful order. Moreover, Ikenberry argues, the liberal international order is 'easy to join and hard to overturn'. Multilateral institutions bear a relatively low threshold for entry and provide great economic and political gains. Finally, Ikenberry finds that emerging powers such as China do not pose a fundamentally different alternative to the existing international order. Actually, he concludes that China, as well as other influential non-Western countries such as Brazil, Russia, India and South Africa, are becoming increasingly more compatible with norms based on liberalism and are becoming integrated into the existing world order.²⁰

A number of points can be made regarding Ikenberry's trust in the triumph of liberalism. First, the correlation between modernization and democratization that Ikenberry assumes to exist has so far not been affirmed in China's case. China is developing successfully under authoritarian rule, with strict limits on political and civil freedoms. A shift of its political system towards democracy has not happened so far, and China's economy seems to thrive nonetheless. Tom Ginsburg states that the democratic peace theory to which Ikenberry adheres does not fit the trajectory that many Asian countries are currently on: 'Only if Asia's political preferences and infant regional institutions magically transformed into mirrors of Europe would we expect an Asia-centred economic order to converge with the European model of politics and law. This outcome seems highly unlikely'.²¹ This is not to say that it is impossible that China will eventually democratize in some way or another. Martin Jacques, author of a widely read but also controversial book, *When China Rules the World*, predicts: 'Chinese democracy will share certain universal characteristics with democracies elsewhere, but will also of necessity be highly distinctive, expressive of its roots in Chinese society and traditions'.²²

From the late nineteenth century, when it lost its status as East Asia's leading power, until the present, China has actively pursued integration into the existing order. This integration has given China great benefits and the costs of 'exiting' would be high. In this regard, it makes sense to say, as Ikenberry does, that the international order is not to be discarded as a relic of the twentieth century, but rather that rising powers

20 Ikenberry, G.J. (2010), 'The Liberal International Order and its Discontents', *Millennium – Journal of International Studies*, 38:509, pp. 514–515.

21 Ginsburg, 'Eastphalia as the Perfection of Westphalia', p. 28.

22 Jacques, M. (2009), *When China Rules the World: The Rise of the Middle Kingdom and the End of the Western World* (London: Allen Lane, Penguin Books), p. 220.

such as China are finding their place within it. This is coherent with China's 'peaceful rise' policy, which has been at the centre of the 'opening up' philosophy that started in Deng Xiaoping's era and has defined China's foreign relations strategy ever since. In 2005, Zheng Bijian wrote that 'China's peaceful rise will further open its economy so that its population can serve as a growing market for the rest of the world, thus providing increased opportunities for – rather than posing a threat to – the international community'.²³ China acknowledges the importance of international cooperation and global governance to its economic development. As Barry Buzan observed, 'China put its own economic development as top priority, and deduced from that the need for stability in its international relations both regionally and globally'.²⁴ Finally, Alastair Iain Johnston stated that, to the extent that one can identify an international community on major global issues, the PRC has become more integrated into international institutions than ever before.²⁵

In 2001, its accession to the WTO meant a great deal to China, precisely because of the economic benefits resulting from accession. However, China's behaviour in negotiations is still deemed controversial. The problem may lie in China's relationship to norms based on liberalism. China's two most important goals in the WTO are to protect its interests better and to build its international image.²⁶ China seems to have little sense of duty to promote liberalism; rather, China feels that it is, at the moment, to its benefit to partake in it. To argue that China integrates into the international order for the sake of liberalism would be to reason the wrong way around: China will be compatible with norms based on liberalism as long as such norms are compatible with Chinese interests. China is not integrating into the liberal international order because it shares the liberal ideology, but because it serves China's needs. Although Ikenberry assumes that China will indefinitely continue to find it useful to act within a system based on liberal values, it could also be argued that at some point in the future, China, as a full-on superpower in both economic and political terms, and finding that its own interests conflict with certain norms based on liberalism, will not be constrained by moral or ideological considerations to neglect these. China currently applies a similar approach to human rights issues, or to its dispute with the United States and the European Union on the value of the yuan.

China is often said to value strongly the idea of Westphalian sovereignty and non-interference. Generally, it has not been supportive of US military interventions, or the institutional-reform side of the Washington Consensus. China's so-called

23 Zheng Bijian (2005), 'China's "Peaceful Rise" to Great-Power Status', *Foreign Affairs*, 84:5, p. 24.

24 Buzan, B. (2010), 'China in International Society: Is "Peaceful Rise" Possible?', *The Chinese Journal of International Politics*, 3, p. 12.

25 Johnston, A.I. (2003), 'Is China a Status Quo Power?', *International Security*, 27:4.

26 Jing Gu, John Humphrey and Dirk Messner (2007), 'Global Governance and Developing Countries: The Implications of the Rise of China', *World Development*, 36:2.

'century of humiliation'²⁷ gave the Chinese government ample reason to be defensive about Chinese sovereignty.²⁸ Indeed, in this sense, China may well out of ideological motivation share a liberal norm with the West.²⁹ However, as Chinese interests are changing, China's support of sovereignty may be changing too. In June 2007, as a member of the UNSC, China persuaded the Sudanese government to accept UN Resolution 1769, which empowered UN troops to use 'all necessary means' to protect themselves, defend civilians and secure the safe passage of aid. Moreover, despite China's initial reluctance to continue supporting a UN mission in Somalia in the 1990s, which it viewed as being intrusive, it later – to the surprise of all other fifteen UNSC members – took the lead in proposing foreign intervention in this same country.³⁰ Under pressure of protecting its own investments in other countries and maintaining its image in the international community, China is also increasingly willing to let go of its principled support of Westphalian sovereignty, at least when it does not concern invasions of its own territory.

Wang Gungwu argues that because China has often seen the United Nations unable to respond to critical power shifts in various parts of the world, prevent violations of the sovereignty of weaker countries by stronger neighbours, help economic development in poorer societies, or save lives in man-made conflicts and natural disasters, it is not wholeheartedly convinced that the liberal international order really works. According to Wang, '[t]herefore, China can be seen as being simply realistic, if not cynical, when it uses the dominant framework to protect and advance its own national interest. There may be not much faith in the system, and little readiness to go out of its way in its defence'.³¹ Wang relates China's stance towards norms based on liberalism in global governance to the idea of perpetual change, as put forward in the ancient Chinese *Book of Changes*, or *Yijing*, that 'the only proposition that does not change is that everything else is subject to change'.³² From this perspective, China has a fundamental distrust in ideas such as Immanuel Kant's perpetual peace and the universality of human rights, which runs against Ikenberry's notion of a lasting liberal international order that will outlive America's hegemony.

27 This refers to the period from the First Opium War to the time when the communists came to power, including the Japanese occupation of China.

28 Jacques, *When China Rules the World*, pp. 70–100.

29 Ginsburg indeed argues that China may be more in touch with the roots of liberalism than many Western countries, as the former promotes Westphalian sovereignty, and the latter undermine them by means of human rights and responsibility to protect; see Ginsburg, 'Eastphalia as the Perfection of Westphalia'.

30 Roque, P.A. and Alden, C. (2008), 'China and the UN Security Council: From Observer to Activist', *SAIIA China in Africa Policy Briefing*, 2, p. 3.

31 Wang Gungwu (2008), 'China and the International Order: Some Historical Perspectives', in Wang Gungwu and Zheng Yongnian (eds), *China and the New International Order* (London: Routledge), p. 22.

32 Wang, 'China and the International Order', p. 23.